

Topic 5

Nuclear fission and nuclear fusion

- 5.1 Describe the structure of nuclei of isotopes using the terms atomic (proton) number and mass (nucleon) number and using symbols in the format ${}^{14}_6\text{C}$
- 5.2 Explain how atoms may gain or lose electrons to form ions
- 5.3 Recall that alpha and beta particles and gamma rays are ionising radiations emitted from unstable nuclei in a random process
- 5.4 Recall that an alpha particle is equivalent to a helium nucleus, a beta particle is an electron emitted from the nucleus and a gamma ray is electromagnetic radiation
- 5.5 Compare alpha, beta and gamma radiations in terms of their abilities to penetrate and ionise
- 5.6 Demonstrate an understanding that nuclear reactions can be a source of energy, including fission, fusion and radioactive decay
- 5.7 Explain how the fission of U-235 produces two daughter nuclei and two or more neutrons, accompanied by a release of energy
- 5.8 Explain the principle of a controlled nuclear chain reaction
- 5.9 Explain how the chain reaction is controlled in a nuclear reactor including the action of moderators and control rods
- 5.10 Describe how thermal (heat) energy from the chain reaction is converted into electrical energy in a nuclear power station
- 5.11 Recall that the products of nuclear fission are radioactive
- 5.12 Describe nuclear fusion as the creation of larger nuclei from smaller nuclei, accompanied by a release of energy and recognise fusion as the energy source for stars
- 5.13 Explain the difference between nuclear fusion and nuclear fission
- 5.14 **Explain why nuclear fusion does not happen at low temperatures and pressures, due to electrostatic repulsion of protons**